

Palpitations & Panic Attacks

Palpitations occur when the heart suddenly beats faster or irregularly. They can result from stress, anxiety, and nervous tension; however, they may also be caused simply by drinking too much caffeine (in tea, coffee, and cola drinks). In rare cases, palpitations indicate a heart problem. They are a key symptom of panic attacks, which are characterized by sudden, acute feelings of fear and anxiety. Linden flowers and valerian root are especially relaxing and calming for the nervous system, specifically helping to reduce underlying anxiety.

General caution Seek immediate professional advice if palpitations last for several minutes.

Palpitations

Herb Linden (*Tilia* spp., p. 277)

Remedy Make an infusion with up to 20 g of linden to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Divide into 3–4 doses and drink throughout the day.

Herb Dan shen (*Salvia miltiorrhiza*, p. 130)

Remedy Make a decoction and take 3–4 doses during the day for up to 1 week. Alternatively, take half the daily dose for up to 2–3 weeks.

Cautions Do not take *dan shen* with anticoagulant or antiplatelet drugs, or during pregnancy.

Panic Attacks

Herbs Linden (*Tilia* spp., p. 277), valerian (*Valeriana officinalis*, p. 148)

Remedy Make an infusion using 1 tsp of linden and ½ tsp of powdered valerian to ¾ cup (150 ml) of water. Drink 2½ cups (600 ml) a day.

Herbs Motherwort (*Leonurus cardiaca*, p. 227), linden (*Tilia* spp., p. 277)

Remedy Make an infusion of motherwort or make an infusion using ½ tsp of each herb to 1 cup (150 ml) of water. Drink up to 4 cups (600 ml) of either remedy a day.

Caution Do not take motherwort during pregnancy.

Cold Extremities & Chilblains

Poor circulation can cause discomfort and painful chilblains (sores caused by poor local blood flow) on the fingers and toes. By stimulating the circulation and getting more “warmth” into the system with herbs and exercise, the blood flow to the hands and feet is improved. Hot, acrid herbs, such as cayenne or ginger, stimulate the flow of blood through the arteries, helping to prevent the development of chilblains.

Exercise

Aerobic exercise is often the key to improving this condition.

General caution Seek professional advice if fingers and toes frequently become cold and numb.

Poor Circulation to the Hands & Feet

Herb Cayenne (*Capsicum frutescens*, p. 74)

Remedy Take cayenne tablets in winter.

Option Add a pinch of cayenne powder or cayenne sauce to every main meal.

Caution Do not take tablets during pregnancy.

Herbs Cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150), northern prickly ash (*Zanthoxylum americanum*, p. 153)

Remedy 1 Make a decoction using 15 g of cramp bark to 3 cups (750 ml) of water and take 3 doses each day.

Remedy 2 Mix 5 g of prickly ash and 10 g of cramp bark and make a decoction using 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Take 3 doses each day.

Caution Do not take prickly ash during pregnancy.

Chilblains

Herbs Ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155), lemon (*Citrus limon*, p. 82), echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92)

Remedy (Internal) Grate 1 tsp of fresh ginger into your food each day. Alternatively, drink ¼ cup (70 ml) of ginger wine each day.

Remedy (External) Apply either fresh ginger, undiluted lemon juice, or neat echinacea tincture to unopened chilblains twice a day.

Note The external remedy helps to prevent blistering and weeping. Once the blister opens you can continue to apply, but it will sting upon contact.

Varicose Veins & Hemorrhoids

Varicose veins result from a weakness, or increased pressure, in the veins. This causes the thin supporting walls of the veins to bulge out, resulting in distended veins and the pooling of blood. Hemorrhoids are usually caused by constipation. Many herbs can be of use in relieving these conditions. Distilled witch hazel is an excellent astringent, and yarrow has healing, astringent, and anti-inflammatory properties.

Self-help

Home treatment should aim to relieve pressure on the veins. Varicose vein sufferers should avoid tight clothing around the waist or legs. To ease hemorrhoids, try to maintain regular bowel movements (see *Constipation & Diarrhea*, p. 307).

General caution Do not massage or rub varicose veins.

Varicose Veins

Herbs Witch hazel (*Hamamelis virginiana*, p. 102), calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy Gently apply distilled witch hazel or witch hazel cream or ointment to the affected area 1–2 times a day, or combine equal parts of the creams of both herbs and apply 1–2 times a day.

NOTE This remedy is particularly effective on painful varicose veins.

Herb Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*, p. 56)

Remedy (External) Wash varicose veins in a cool infusion, or apply the ointment 1–2 times a day.

Remedy (Internal) Make an infusion and leave for 10 minutes. Take ¾–1¼ cups (150–300 ml) a day for up to 10 weeks.

Caution Do not take yarrow during pregnancy.

Hemorrhoids

Herbs Witch hazel (*Hamamelis virginiana*, p. 102), lesser celandine (*Ranunculus ficaria*, p. 260), common oak (*Quercus robur*, p. 260), calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy 1 Apply either distilled witch hazel or witch hazel ointment, or lesser celandine ointment, 1–2 times a day.

Remedy 2 Mix 1 tsp of common oak bark powder with 2½ tbsps of calendula ointment and apply 1–2 times a day.

Difficult Passage of the Stool & Painful Hemorrhoids

Herb Slippery elm (*Ulmus rubra*, p. 145)

Remedy Take either slippery elm “food” (see *Acidity & Indigestion*, p. 307) or tablets.

Herb Psyllium (*Plantago* spp., p. 123)

Remedy Take 1–2 tsp of seeds soaked in ¾ cup (150 ml) of water overnight, twice a day.